

How Might We (HMW)

Turn insights into optimistic, open solution prompts

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

'How Might We...' questions reframe a point-of-view problem as an invitation to ideate. The phrasing is deliberate: **How** assumes solutions exist, **Might** gives permission to fail, and **We** makes it collaborative. Good HMWs are neither too broad nor too narrow.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Coined at Procter & Gamble by Min Basadur in the 1970s and popularised through IDEO and the d.school.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

A raw problem statement can feel like a wall. HMW converts it into an open, optimistic prompt that a group can brainstorm against.

FIGURE 1 · FRAMING AN OPPORTUNITY



Figure 1. Each word of 'How might we' does work; the art is pitching the question between too broad and too narrow.

HOW IT IS USED

Take the PoV, generate several HMW variants at different scopes, then select the one that feels most generative — broad enough for many ideas, focused enough to be useful.

WHEN IT IS USED

The bridge between Define and Ideate.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Facilitators, design and product teams.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It engineers the **psychology of the question** itself, priming a group for generative rather than defensive thinking — a small phrasing shift with outsized effect.

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Point of View (PoV) *Slibrary 6*

Brainstorming *Slibrary 7*

Storytelling *Slibrary 6*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Basadur, M. (1994) *Simplex: A Flight to Creativity*. Buffalo, NY: Creative Education Foundation.

Interaction Design Foundation (2026) 'What is How Might We (HMW)?'. Available at: <https://www.interaction-design.org/literature/topics/how-might-we> (Accessed: 20 July 2026).